

August 2026

Dear Charles Mark,

I've worked in Lamorinda real estate for a long time, and properties like 490 St. Marys Road don't come along very often. A gated lot of nearly an acre and a half, a creek running through it, no visible neighbors, and a home built by a contractor with enough pride in the work to choose every material himself - that's a genuinely rare combination for Lafayette. When I saw the listing come off the market without a sale after 31 days, I wanted to understand why, because the fundamentals here are real.

My honest read is that the listing strategy didn't do justice to what this property actually is. The description hints at something extraordinary - the custom finishes, the kitchen, the setting - but it never builds the picture that a buyer at this price point needs before they'll drive out for a showing. At \$2,800,000, buyers are comparing carefully, and a listing that reads as a series of enthusiastic fragments doesn't give them the visual evidence or the narrative confidence to act. The home's story was there. It just wasn't told in a way that landed.

I've put together an analysis of the specific gaps I see and a blueprint for how a relaunch could be structured differently. It walks through the pricing position, the buyer profile most likely to move on a property like this, and the media strategy that would let the creek, the setting, and the craftsmanship do the actual selling.

If you're already working with an agent toward a new listing, please feel free to set this aside - no offense taken. But if you're still weighing your options, I'd welcome a short conversation. No pressure, no pitch - just a walk through what I've put together.

With respect,



Ben Olsen

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The Path to Sold:

490 St Marys Rd

Lafayette, CA 94549

4.0 Beds · 3 Baths · 3,144 Sq Ft · Lafayette

The Blueprint for a Successful Sale

Prepared For: The Owners of 490 St Marys Rd

Presented By: Ben Olsen · BrightWork Realty Advocates

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A Custom-Built Creek Estate on 1.5 Acres - and a Listing That Never Showed It

490 St. Marys Road is, by almost any measure, exactly what the upper end of the Lafayette market is looking for. A gated, 65,340-square-foot lot with Las Trampas Creek running through it, no visible neighbors, a through-driveway, a three-car garage, and a home built by an owner-contractor who sourced premium materials and handled the craft personally. The kitchen alone was described as a showpiece. Each window frames the natural setting like a photograph. These are not manufactured selling points - they are genuine, defensible differentiators in a market where most homes at this price point sit on conventional lots with conventional views.

And yet the listing came off the market in 31 days without a sale. The gap between the home's assets and that outcome points almost entirely to a strategy problem, not a property problem. The listing description read more like a contractor's walk-through notes than a narrative designed to move a buyer emotionally and financially. The visual media did not appear to capture the creek, the setting at dusk, the sense of privacy, or the craftsmanship detail that would have justified the price in a buyer's mind before they ever scheduled a showing. At \$891 per square foot - the upper tier of the Lafayette premium range - buyers need more than enthusiasm. They need visual proof and a story that holds together.

\$2,800,000

List Price

\$891/sqft

Price Per Sq. Ft.

None

HOA Fees

A relaunch of this property needs to accomplish one specific thing: give the right buyer - likely a professional couple or family relocating from San Francisco or the Oakland hills, drawn by privacy, land, and craftsmanship - enough visual and narrative evidence online to feel confident booking a showing. That is a solvable problem, and this home has all the raw material to solve it.

MARKET FORENSICS: WHY IT DIDN'T SELL

Every expired listing has a story. Here's what the listing history tells us about what held this one back, and what a different strategy would have done.

Friction #1: The Narrative Never Matched the Property

The listing description for 490 St. Marys Road gestures at something exceptional without ever delivering it. Phrases like 'looks like paradise' and 'saying WOW' are emotional reactions, not descriptions - they tell a buyer how they should feel rather than giving them the sensory detail that actually produces that feeling. At \$2,800,000, buyers are reading listings with discipline and skepticism. A description that reads like enthusiastic fragments invites them to scroll past rather than book a showing. The creek, the privacy, the contractor-grade custom finishes, the kitchen - each of those deserved its own specific sentence, and none of them got one.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork listing remarks are written the way a great buyer's agent describes a home - specific, sensory, and structured to answer the questions a serious buyer is already asking. For a property like this, the description is the first showing.

Friction #2: A Premium Price Point With No Visual Proof

At \$891 per square foot, this home sits at the upper end of Lafayette's premium tier. That number is defensible - the lot size, the creek, the custom construction, and the absence of visible neighbors are genuine premium inputs. But a defensible price is not a self-evident one. Buyers comparing this home against others in the \$2.5M to \$3M Lafayette range needed to see the creek from the deck, the light in the kitchen, the scale of the lot from above, and the sense of enclosure that makes the privacy real. Without that visual evidence, a buyer's instinct is to assume the price is optimistic rather than justified.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork's Sky Tour uses aerial video to show lot position, creek frontage, and natural setting in ways ground photography simply cannot replicate - giving buyers the spatial context that turns a price into a bargain rather than a question mark.

Friction #3: The Right Buyer Was Never Actively Reached

The buyer for a gated, creek-front, 1.5-acre estate in Lafayette with no HOA is a specific person - likely a professional or executive household, probably relocating from San Francisco or the Oakland hills, searching for land, privacy, and a home with genuine character. That buyer was not waiting on the open MLS for the right listing to appear. They were researching Lamorinda from their desk in the city, cross-referencing neighborhoods, and forming opinions before they ever contacted an agent. A standard MLS distribution strategy put this home in front of everyone equally, which in practice means it reached the right buyer only by chance. Thirty-one days passed without a sale, which strongly suggests that buyer was never found.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork runs geo-targeted digital campaigns that reach San Francisco and East Bay buyers who are actively researching Lamorinda before they've identified their target home - putting this property in front of the right household at the right moment in their search, not after they've already moved on.

POSITIONING ANALYSIS

Metric	490 St. Marys Rd	Lafayette Market Context
Price per Sq. Ft.	\$891/sqft	Premium tier: \$850–\$920/sqft
Lot / Setting	65,340 sqft (1.5 acres), gated, creek-front, no visible neighbors	Typical Lafayette lot: 8,000–15,000 sqft, conventional setting
Architectural Character	Owner-contractor custom build, premium materials, artistic detail throughout	Standard spec construction or builder-grade finishes
Premium Features	Las Trampas Creek frontage, through-gated driveway, 3-car garage with wood doors, showpiece kitchen	2-car garage, standard kitchen, no water feature
HOA	None	Varies; \$0–\$300/mo depending on community

The verdict: At \$891/sqft versus a benchmark range of \$850-\$920/sqft, this home sits in the middle of that range. At \$891 per square foot, this home sits near the middle of Lafayette's premium tier, and the underlying assets - the lot size, the creek, the custom construction, the privacy - genuinely support that position. The issue was never the number. A relaunch needs to focus on building the visual and narrative case that makes \$891 feel like the obvious price for what this property actually delivers, rather than a figure a buyer has to take on faith.

THE RELAUNCH STRATEGY: 3 PILLARS

We don't re-list this home. We relaunch it with new media, a narrative that finally does it justice, and distribution designed for the buyer it deserves.

Pillar I - Tell the Story the Creek and the Land Deserve

490 St. Marys Road has a setting that most Lafayette buyers have never encountered at this price point: a gated, creek-front, 1.5-acre lot with no visible neighbors and wildlife moving through it seasonally. That story requires more than a few enthusiastic phrases in the MLS remarks - it requires listing copy structured around specific sensory detail, written the way a buyer's agent would describe it to a client who trusts their judgment. The first conversation this home has with a potential buyer needs to make them feel what it's like to be there. BrightWork builds that narrative before anything goes live.

Pillar II - Show the Property From the Air and From Inside

The features that justify a premium on this home - the creek, the lot scale, the depth of the custom finishes - are invisible in standard MLS photography. A buyer looking at flat ground-level shots has no way to understand the spatial relationship between the home, the creek, and the surrounding landscape. BrightWork's 3D Matterport tour lets buyers walk the interior from anywhere, at any time, so the craftsmanship and the kitchen read as premium before a single showing is booked. The media package for a property like this needs to do the work of qualifying buyers before they arrive at the door.

Pillar III - Find the Buyer Who Is Already Looking for This

The household most likely to pay full value for 490 St. Marys Road is probably sitting in San Francisco or the Oakland hills right now, researching Lamorinda, and looking for exactly this combination: privacy, land, craftsmanship, and no HOA. That buyer responds to targeted exposure, not passive MLS presence. BrightWork's off-market private buyer list at offmarket.brightworkrealty.com gives us a direct line to Bay Area buyers who have opted in to receive property alerts before anything reaches Zillow - a clean, credible first impression with the people most likely to act.

A DIFFERENT OPTION: THE QUIET LISTING

Sell Without the Disruption

A traditional listing puts a sign in your yard, opens your door to strangers every weekend, and puts your home's history on public record. For a home that already went through one listing cycle, there's a better starting point.

BrightWork maintains an active private buyer list through our off-market platform. These are Bay Area buyers who've opted in specifically to receive property alerts before anything hits Zillow. They're motivated, pre-qualified, and they believe an off-market home represents a real opportunity, which means they engage seriously.

- * **No public days on market.** The prior listing history stays private. A new buyer sees none of it.
- * **No sign, no open houses, no disruption.** The sale is a private conversation between a motivated buyer and a motivated seller.
- * **Option to go public anytime.** If the right off-market offer doesn't materialize in an agreed window, we transition directly into a full relaunch strategy with no time lost.

* HOW IT WORKS

We alert our private buyer list through offmarket.brightworkrealty.com - Bay Area buyers specifically seeking properties before they go public. If a serious match emerges within the agreed window, we negotiate and close privately. If not, we launch the full relaunch strategy immediately, with clean momentum and no days-on-market exposure.

TIMELINE: THE BRIGHTWORK SMART WAY

Phase 1 - Pre-Market Preparation (Weeks 1–2)

Staging, full media production, and a Coming Soon campaign - or a quiet listing launch to our private buyer network, depending on your preference.

Phase 2 - Strategic Launch (Week 3)

Thursday launch on Zillow Showcase with the full media package in premium placement. Targeted SF/Oakland digital ads go live the same day.

Phase 3 - Momentum Management (Weeks 4–5)

Active follow-up on every save, inquiry, and open house visitor. Final Offer gives serious buyers a transparent channel to submit competitive offers.

Phase 4 - The Close (Weeks 6–7)

We engineer competition, not just field offers. Our process keeps both sides of the transaction moving cleanly toward a close.

WHY BRIGHTWORK REALTY ADVOCATES

- * **Deep local roots:** 45+ years in Moraga, Lafayette, and Orinda. Ground-level knowledge of what buyers in each community are actually paying for.
- * **Premium marketing as a baseline:** Cinematic photography, floor plans, 3D tours, and Sky Tours on every listing. Not a luxury add-on.
- * **Portal dominance:** Zillow Showcase and homes.com premium placement. More views, enhanced listing pages, all leads to your team.
- * **Modern offer tools:** Final Offer gives buyers a transparent path to engage and gives you real-time demand data in one place.
- * **True advocacy:** We don't re-list homes. We forensically review what went wrong and rebuild the strategy from the ground up.

This home has real assets that the market never got to properly evaluate. That's a correctable problem. The window to correct it is still open.

Ready to talk? brightworkrealty.com · (925) 255-9727

Scan to see what a relaunch looks like for your home: relaunch.brightworkrealty.com

Important Notice

If you have entered into a listing agreement or active representation agreement with a licensed real estate agent in connection with this property, please disregard this mailing.

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The market analysis and strategic observations contained in this report are based on publicly available listing data and BrightWork's professional assessment of market conditions. They are not a formal appraisal and should not be relied upon as a certified valuation.

All property data referenced in this report was obtained from public records and MLS history. BrightWork Realty Advocates makes no warranty as to the accuracy of third-party data sources.

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